

Strategic Insights Report

A cross-sectional analysis of brand equity across 54 institutions, surfacing visibility gaps, marketing leverage, and growth signals.

54 INSTITUTIONS ANALYZED	7 BRAND EQUITY DIMENSIONS	74 TOP SCORE — UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN
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Executive Summary

Five findings stand out across the 54-institution dataset. Each one points to a strategic question marketing and enrollment leadership should be ready to answer.

01 Brand equity tracks Carnegie classification — but only loosely.

R1 Doctoral institutions average **60.9**, more than double Liberal Arts colleges at **29.2**. Yet the highest-scoring liberal arts institution outperforms the lowest R1 by 8 points, showing that classification is a baseline, not a ceiling.

02 Visibility and research are nearly the same signal ($r = +0.94$).

These two dimensions move together so tightly that institutions investing in one are effectively investing in the other. The implication: standalone marketing-only campaigns rarely move the brand equity needle without research narrative behind them.

03 Big Four conference membership is worth ~27 points of brand equity.

Big Four schools (n=26) average 59.6 overall vs. 32.5 for non-Big Four (n=28). Athletic affiliation is the single largest discrete brand asset in this dataset.

04 Diversity & access run inversely to visibility ($r = -0.28$).

The schools serving the most Pell-eligible and first-gen students score lowest on the visibility axis. This is a sector-wide narrative gap, not an institutional failure — community colleges and access-focused schools are systematically under-told.

05 A small cohort is materially out-marketing its research base.

Six institutions show a visibility-over-research gap of 35+ points (Villanova, Butler, Elon, JMU, Smith, Gonzaga). These are the brand-building case studies — what they're doing replicably is the question for everyone else.

The Leaderboard

Composite Brand Equity Score (0–100) blends seven dimensions, weighted by Carnegie type and QS band.

Top 10 Overall

#	Institution	Type	Score
1	University of Michigan	R1 Doctoral	74
2	University of Washington	R1 Doctoral	71
3	University of North Carolina Chapel Hill	R1 Doctoral	69
4	University of Texas at Austin	R1 Doctoral	69
5	Ohio State University	R1 Doctoral	68
6	University of Wisconsin-Madison	R1 Doctoral	68
7	University of Florida	R1 Doctoral	68
8	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	R1 Doctoral	66
9	University of Minnesota	R1 Doctoral	65
10	Pennsylvania State University	R1 Doctoral	63

Bottom 10 Overall

Lower composite scores often reflect mission focus (liberal arts, special focus, access institutions) rather than brand weakness — they signal where the dimension weights diverge most from peer norms.

#	Institution	Type	Score
45	Duquesne University	R3 Doctoral	29
46	Elon University	M1 Masters	29
47	Quinnipiac University	M1 Masters	29
48	Middlebury College	Liberal Arts	29
49	Columbus State Community College	Associates	29
50	Thomas Jefferson University	Special Focus	28
51	MCPHS University	Special Focus	28

52	Denison University	Liberal Arts	26
53	Scripps College	Liberal Arts	26
54	Gettysburg College	Liberal Arts	25

By Carnegie Classification

Mean composite scores normalize for type-specific weight profiles, so cross-type comparison reflects relative dimension strength.

Classification	N	Mean	Median
R1 Doctoral	25	60.9	61
Research Elite	2	42	42.0
R2 Doctoral	4	40	40.5
R3 Doctoral	3	31.7	33
Associates	3	31.7	32
M1 Masters	6	30.8	30.5
Liberal Arts	9	29.2	30
Special Focus	2	28	28.0

Brand Equity by QS Ranking Band

Global ranking position remains the single most predictive external signal.

QS Band	N	Mean Overall
QS Top 100	4	70
QS 101–200	6	59.5
QS 201–400	10	59.3
QS 401–600	6	55.8
QS 601+	8	37.9
QS Unranked	20	29.6

Dimension Leaders

The institutions setting the bar on each of the seven brand equity dimensions.

Visibility & Reach

Rank	Institution	Score
1	University of Michigan	77
2	University of Washington	76
3	University of Texas at Austin	76
4	University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign	76
5	University of Wisconsin-Madison	75

Enrollment & Retention

Rank	Institution	Score
1	University of Liverpool	81
2	Williams College	77
3	Bowdoin College	77
4	Queen's University (Ontario)	77
5	Amherst College	76

Financial Strength

Rank	Institution	Score
1	Queen's University (Ontario)	11
2	University of Liverpool	10

Institutional Profile

Rank	Institution	Score
1	University of Michigan	94
2	University of Washington	90

3	University of Texas at Austin	90
4	Ohio State University	81
5	University of Minnesota	81

Academic & Research

Rank	Institution	Score
1	University of Michigan	85
2	Ohio State University	83
3	University of Washington	82
4	University of Wisconsin-Madison	82
5	Texas A&M University	81

Diversity & Access

Rank	Institution	Score
1	Miami Dade College	55
2	Valencia College	49
3	Columbus State Community College	45
4	Arizona State University	30
5	Rutgers University-New Brunswick	26

The Visibility–Research Gap

Where is the brand story out-running the substance? And where is the substance out-running the brand?

Marketing-Forward Institutions

Visibility scores meaningfully exceed research scores. These are the brand machines — primarily teaching-focused universities punching above their R&D; weight class through positioning, athletics, and audience cultivation.

Institution	Visibility	Research	Gap
Villanova University	41	2	+39
Butler University	38	0	+38
Elon University	38	0	+38
James Madison University	38	1	+37
Smith College	36	0	+36
Gonzaga University	36	1	+35

Under-Leveraged Research Institutions

Research output exceeds visibility — substantive work that the broader market is not pricing into the brand. Marketing investment here typically returns the most.

Institution	Research	Visibility	Gap
Thomas Jefferson University	29	14	+16

Enrollment Momentum

Five-year headcount trends — the leading indicator of demand-side brand health.

Fastest Growing

Institution	5-Yr Trend
Arizona State University	+5.8%
Valencia College	+3.8%
Texas A&M University	+3.4%
Purdue University	+3.2%
University of Florida	+2.9%

Sharpest Declines

Institution	5-Yr Trend
Duquesne University	-1.9%
Smith College	-2.0%
University of Kansas	-2.1%
Columbus State Community College	-2.4%
Drexel University	-3.2%

How the Dimensions Move Together

Pairwise correlations across the dataset reveal which brand levers are independent — and which are effectively the same.

Dimension A	Dimension B	r	Reading
Visibility	Research	+0.94	Strong positive
Visibility	Enrollment	+0.13	Weak positive
Research	Diversity	-0.18	Weak negative
Visibility	Diversity	-0.28	Weak negative
Financial	Visibility	-1.00	Strong negative
Research	Enrollment	+0.08	No relationship
Alumni	Visibility	+0.00	No relationship
Overall	Enrollment	+0.18	Weak positive

What it means

- **Visibility ↔ Research (+0.94):** the strongest pairing in the dataset. Brand investment without research substance — or vice versa — is rare and short-lived.
- **Visibility ↔ Diversity (–0.28):** the institutions doing the most for access are the least visible. A persistent sector-level gap and an opportunity for differentiated positioning.
- **Overall ↔ Enrollment (+0.18):** brand equity is only weakly correlated with five-year enrollment trend, meaning brand strength does not guarantee growth — and enrollment dips do not immediately damage brand.

Methodology

How the Brand Equity Score is constructed.

Source data. 52 U.S. institutions and 2 international institutions, drawn from the IPEDS extract embedded in the Higher Education Brand Index application. Fields include US News, QS, THE, Niche, and Caldwell rankings; IPEDS retention and graduation rates; NSF HERD R&D; expenditures; doctoral degree output; Carnegie classification; and self-reported social audience footprint.

Seven dimensions. Visibility & Reach, Enrollment & Retention, Financial Strength, Institutional Profile, Academic & Research Reputation, Diversity & Access, and Alumni Engagement. Each dimension is scored 0–100 by normalizing its inputs against expected ranges (US News rank inverted within its list; binary checkboxes contribute presence + ranked-program bonuses).

Composite weighting. The overall score blends two weight profiles — one based on Carnegie classification (R1 weights research and visibility heavily; bac/arts weights alumni and enrollment) and one based on QS band (top-100 institutions face stiffer visibility standards). Weights are averaged and re-normalized.

What this is not. This is a working analytical model, not an authoritative ranking. Alumni inputs are sparse in the current sample; financial inputs are not populated for U.S. institutions. Treat absolute scores as directional and use peer-relative gaps for decision-making.